

Fellowship

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One of the reasons why Cambridge seems rather strange and ‘out of time’ is that it has for long been to a certain extent a ‘total institution’. With many dons now married, and many working well away from the Colleges, this has changed greatly in the last half century. But still for undergraduates in term-time and nowadays for a few resident fellows, we see a glimpse of this rather unusual situation. In our modern individualistic and highly mobile societies there are few such encompassing worlds. Those that do exist are usually there because people have, somewhat involuntarily, been placed in them; boarding schools where children are ‘sent’, hospitals, mental institutions and prisons. Another two main forms likewise cut off from the community, but based on choice, monastic institutions and the army. Cambridge is very much part of society and absorbs ordinary people for short periods and it is voluntarily entered. Yet there is also a certain totality about the place.

The central feature of all these total institutions is that different parts of life occur within one physical space – sleeping, eating, drinking, sport, prayer and thought. The walls, literal or virtual, are there to form a strong boundary between ‘the outside’ and the intensely overlapping worlds within.

When Cambridge Colleges were first built they were like monasteries. The Fellows were there for life, could not marry, slept, ate, prayed, played and thought in one physical space. A College nowadays always has the facilities for eating and drinking, the social centres of bars and the often splendid dining halls, most have Chapels for worship, libraries and studies for thought, the grounds for play.

When I try to explain to a visiting scholar from Nepal or China how Cambridge works I ask them to imagine the quadrangle of my College as a Newar courtyard in Nepal, or a clan village with its ancestor hall in parts of traditional China. There is one marked difference, however, and this is the root of the puzzle. The Nepalese and Chinese examples are based on kinship, while Cambridge attempted to set itself against kinship as a basis of recruitment. Fellows were not allowed to marry and so could not pass on their position to their children, although they might sometimes do so to their nephews.

It is this mixture of total institution, but one which is not based on birth or even a perpetual vow of membership (monastic) but rather on choice and supposed merit, that makes Cambridge feel such an odd hybrid, a ‘total’ institution based on competitive, achieved, admission. It is to a considerable extent a ‘community’ in sentiment and identity, based on the unities of place and a feeling of shared identity, but not on blood. It thus has two out of the three criteria for true community specified by Tönnies and others. So how does it work?

One way to think about Cambridge is to use the ideas developed by one of its most famous lawyers (and Master of Trinity Hall), Sir Henry Maine. Drawing on Roman Law and his experience of Cambridge, Maine elaborated the idea of the corporation, that is a constructed set of rights in property and people *which never dies*.

A western corporation is set up by a conscious act – a grant from the State giving it delegated powers. It is endowed with many of the attributes of a fictive person. It can hold property in common, it has limited liability and it joins or incorporates people. It can last forever. Individual members hold things in common or in some kind of shared way. Each member is like a limb, a head, feet, arm, of a body (*corpus*) – joined to each other and drawing sustenance from each other. To lop off the Master, the Bursar, the Dean, is like cutting off the head, arms or heart of a College.

Maine's fruitful idea was found to be applicable not only to Cambridge but around the world as anthropologists tried to understand the various ethnic groups being incorporated into the British Empire. Some of the deepest insights in the anthropological understanding of how non-western societies were held together derive from the application of this insight by more recent anthropologists.

Kinship groups, or descent groups as they are known, operate in much the same way as Cambridge Colleges. They hold tangible and intangible property in common and are perpetual. They bind the members not through blood alone, but through marriage and the selection of a principle of descent, through males or females. With the concept of corporation, anthropologists found a solution to the problem of what maintained social order in societies without a centralized state.

Reversing the idea, we can see the Colleges as equivalent to descent groups, that is clans of people who have a corporate unity and identity. But while anthropologists recognize that many of the bonds in a descent group are fictional, constructed this is carried to a much further extent in Cambridge Colleges where people are almost entirely recruited on non-kin lines.

The existence of a perpetual, property owning, corporation or College, among other things, gives the members of the group a feeling that they belong to something larger than themselves. In monasteries and nunneries this is expressed and reinforced by the use of quasi-kin terms, for the members call each other 'brother', 'sister', 'father' or 'mother'. For various reasons this does not happen in Cambridge. Although one of my senior colleagues addresses all of us in his emails as 'Dear Chums', this is also not exactly the word, with its evocation of Edwardian adventure stories. The chosen word is 'Fellow'.

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What precisely is a Fellow?¹ The word fellowship has a long and distinguished history. One on-line dictionary gives some of the meanings as follows:

- 1. a. The condition of sharing similar interests, ideals, or experiences, as by reason of profession, religion, or nationality.*
- b. The companionship of individuals in a congenial atmosphere and on equal terms.*
- 2. A close association of friends or equals sharing similar interests.*
- 3. Friendship; comradeship.*

So it denotes equality, friendship, closeness, but also (implicitly) a separate identity and dignity. One model for its meaning is King Arthur's 'Fellowship of the Round Table'. A more recent example is in that very Oxbridge story, 'The Fellowship of the Ring' by J.R. Tolkien, Fellow of Merton, Oxford, who deliberately modelled his work on the Arthurian Fellowship.

There are many varieties of Fellowship - Senior and Junior, Life and Honorary, Official and Unofficial, but they are all Fellows and should treat each other not merely with respect but as instituted friends.

Fellowship, in other words, is a status. This came home to me when we were inventing new terms for those who give generously to my College. A number of people suggested they be called 'Donor Fellows' or using some other adjective attached to Fellows. I felt this was completely wrong in a way I could not quite articulate for a while.

So I suggested (and it was approved) that the word Fellow be used as an adjective – 'Fellow Commoner' or some such. This described their closeness without changing their status and making them actually Fellows, with all the implications of becoming part of the Governing Body. The same issue came up recently with Life Fellows. Some argued that the entitlement to a Life Fellowship after 25 years of being a Fellow should be limited to social rights, but not membership of the governing body with voting rights. Others argued that if one is a Fellow one is a full Fellow, or not one at all. It is a status that cannot be chopped into bits.

Fellowship generates sentiment, a feeling of closeness and being of one body, but, just like a family, it does not necessarily generate affection. You don't necessarily like all the Fellows, just as you may not like some of your family. For many purposes, whatever your personal feelings, you feel some sense of respect, closeness and trust. When I recognize Fellows on the streets of Cambridge, I greet them.² When I sit down next to one of them

¹ Peter Burke comments that 'the word is difficult to translate, one reason that Pierre Bourdieu decided to leave my piece on Emma in English. In Portuguese I tried 'sócio', but it suggests a business relationship, or 'membro', which ignores our distinction between fellows and members.

² Though Peter Burke tells me that in Emmanuel in 1980 one did not greet Fellows.

at a meal, I feel a sense of shared identity. This takes away a little of the isolation and separateness which is a strong feature of the individualistic English.

The secret, I suppose, as with King Arthur's knights, is the feeling of a shared goal. You are a team, but not one that is trying to score the most goals, or win a race, but together you are trying to push forward the task you accepted in the oath you took when you joined the Fellowship. Jointly, you are trying to promote the College as a centre of 'education, religion, knowledge and research'.

It is this sense of shared task, ineffable yet rewarding, which sometimes spreads to others in longer-term contact with the College – porters, secretaries, gardeners - which helps to explain an anomaly. This is that while the written contractual obligations of a University teacher or Fellow are often almost non-existent, I have found myself doing many extra hours and tasks beyond the limit of the call of duty derived from some diffuse sense of obligation, debt, desire for approbation, or desire to reciprocate the perceived efforts of others.

Of course there are a few 'free riders' and minimal participants, and there are times when I put in more effort than at others. Yet it is generally the case that a sense of privileged belonging, a desire to be thought of as worthy of the Fellowship or the University, is a nebulous force which drives me on. The University and College become something like the Protestant idea of God – constantly there, watching, praising, encouraging and occasionally showing signs of disapproval at some failure or lack of effort.

Charities and trust

The Charity Commission is in charge of a multitude of different Trusts, from the very large, like the Catholic Church in England and Wales, to the medium sized ones like the Cambridge Colleges. These Trusts are part of a system which is a complement to the idea of corporations. For there is a great danger in corporation theory in its Roman form and as applied undiluted in Roman law countries. Henry Maine's successor, the Downing Professor of Law at Cambridge, F.W.Maitland, pointed this out. Maitland's theories take us to the heart of the mystery of Cambridge.

Corporation theory is not sufficient to explain the distinctive success of Oxbridge. Corporations existed all over Western Europe. Yet in France, Germany, Italy and elsewhere they did not lead to a continued, flourishing, set of independent universities after their early successful beginnings. This is because, as Maitland shows, corporations are in essence created by rulers. Their independent life is given to them as a conditional and withdrawable gift by royal power.

Maitland uses the metaphor of breathing life into dead matter; the corporation comes to life through the kiss of a charter from the ruling power. And at any time the State, if it feels the corporation is too powerful, too independent, or refuses to pay enough taxes, can

turn off the oxygen. Some supplementary legal model or device is needed to explain what happened in England.

A further problem with corporations is that they do not create the warmth, the sentiment, which is needed to make people work closely and well together. To be a member of a big corporation does not necessarily mean that one feels any special affection or diffused obligation to do more than the bare minimum. It is different in many large Japanese companies it is true, but that is part of a deep basic difference in Japanese civilization.

So what created the affect, and overcame the dependence on the State?

The answer which Maitland gives is the Trust. The Trust was originally a legal device used in the Middle Ages by the rich in order to avoid death duties. A fictive person, a body of trustees, was set up. They held some rights in property 'in trust' for the use of a person's heirs after they died. Quite soon the model spread out to provide the template of institutions as varied as the Inns of Court, the Stock Exchange, Lloyds Insurance, the Methodists, the Trades Unions and the London Clubs. Although the University is somewhere on the borderline between corporations and trusts, the colleges, by outright gifts of property from royal and other donors, are in effect independent.

With the model of Trusts all around them, the University and Colleges were treated and acted as if they were Trusts. They were, in modern terms, quasi-autonomous non-governmental institutions. The Master and Fellows were entrusted with the maintenance and good governance of the College. The Colleges are in effect Trusts in the terms of the Charity Commissioners and we are often told as Fellows that we are officially Trustees of the College.

One of the most difficult and scarce commodities in all spheres of life is trust, that is the ability to take the risk to share and exchange whatever is the scarce resource - love, wealth, reputation, power - with others. Where trust exists it greatly increases efficiency and effectiveness since people can work together without the friction of checking and testing, without the inhibitions of competition and secrecy. Trust is usually in short supply; its presence is the exception that needs to be explained. As Maitland shows, this not only gives the Colleges and University a legal framework for perpetual liberty and independence, but also induces trust and loyalty.

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One of the greatest pleasures in my time in Cambridge is that I have usually been able to trust my colleagues, both in the Department and the College. On the whole, the presumption has always been that ideas, opinions, reputations are safe with my friends and colleagues. If I ask their opinion, I assume that they will try to be helpful and truthful. I assume that they will try to put the general good of the organization before their private desires and ambitions as much as possible. This trust also extends to my students, who have almost universally shown themselves worthy of this trust.

In academic life this is not just important in running the organization, in writing and reading references, evaluations or feedback about ideas and people. Also at a deeper level it is absolutely essential for the co-operative pursuit of knowledge in any field. It is often the case, I am told, that in some Universities, having invested so much in their work, academics become distrustful and secretive. They hoard their hard-won information and ideas, fencing it off with large invisible notices, 'Private Property', 'Don't Trespass'. This is something I have rarely experienced.

Obviously if a person is still developing a really paradigm shattering idea they can, like Charles Darwin, conceal what they have found for a while. Yet I have always found that it is perfectly easy to lecture, give papers, teach or talk about current work without fear of the ideas being 'stolen' or mis-used. Although there is an increasing fear of concealed copying and plagiarism, especially with the development of the Internet, and certain extremely financially valuable ideas are no doubt concealed, perhaps because I work in the arts and humanities I have never found the sharing of my current ideas to be a problem in Cambridge.

It may be that I am an extreme case, for I have dumped many of my published and unpublished writings, as well as early drafts and the original sources onto the public world of the internet, and, before that, published a great deal on microfiches and other forms. This is partly because I have found that trust and distrust are self-fulfilling prophecies. If you trust someone, they tend to live up to the trust. If you distrust them, they will react in a negative way, which suggests that one was right to distrust them.

The warmth which being charitable and trusting towards others creates is one of the joys of working in Cambridge. There are many anthropological accounts of societies and civilizations where life is filled with suspicion, distrust and rivalry. Such distrust clogs emotions, inhibits intellectual co-operation and development. It amazes me to find a large intellectual organization which has lasted eight hundred years and which, certainly in the period I have been present, is largely based on mutual trust and respect. It is, I believe, one of the very most important clues to Cambridge's intellectual eminence and the attraction it exercises over those who join it.

I suspect that those who come into contact with Cambridge, as academic visitors or students, often sense this. They may feel some lecturers are not good at lecturing and some teachers are worn out and have lost their originality. Yet I have never come across the complaint that their teachers are hiding their important work, that there are secrets and lies mixed up with the flow of information. The burden of secrecy is relatively low, perhaps lower than in a family where much has to be screened off, by parents from their children and children from their parents. Of course much must be kept confidential, but that is another matter. For trust in the robustness of observance of rules of confidentiality is another form of trust and confidence.

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Cambridge is not an oasis of trust in a desert of distrust. It is a striking example because of its institutional structure of something wider. Emerson in the middle of the nineteenth century wondered 'Is it the smallness of the country, or is it the pride and affection of race, - they have solidarity, or responsibility, and trust in each other.' And he noted that 'Private men keep their promises, never so trivial.'³ Around the same time, Samuel Laing, comparing continental Europe to England, wrote that 'In all the common business of trade, even to the greatest amount, mutual reliance, not mutual distrust, is the rule; and transactions in the ordinary affairs of life depend upon the good faith, the word, the custom of the parties, much more than upon legal deeds and written contracts of fulfilment.' He also wrote that 'Confidence, moral confidence, between man and man is the peculiar characteristic of the spirit of society in England. It is the lay religion of the English people...' adding that 'This mutual confidence in, and dependence on, each other for what is right, fair, and reasonable between man and man, creates what it relies upon...'⁴

It is this characteristic of trust creating trust that I have normally encountered in Cambridge. I have noticed that it is being undermined by accountancy culture and bureaucratic suspicion, by the often undermining and time-wasting efforts to justify and promote oneself in the periodic Research Assessment Exercises and other uncomprehending reviews. Yet it still survives in an unusually effective way despite everything.

Clubs and communities

The Trust was the original model for the English club. In defining what is special about Cambridge it is worth thinking about how far Cambridge is a club.

The central feature of a club lies in its organization. It consists of a name - the Athenaeum or the Lode Social Club. It has some premises, permanent or hired. It usually has some other assets - a library, a games field, or whatever is necessary for pursuing its special aims. It has a management committee and some officers - President, Treasurer. It sometimes has a flag, motto, or symbol of identity, a tie, a shirt or other markers. If it is highly prestigious like the Royal Society or British Academy, it spends a lot of time discussing who may be invited or allowed to join it.

In all of these respects both the Colleges and the University of Cambridge seem to be large intellectual clubs. They overlap with London clubs, the Inns of Court and many others. The atmosphere of the Senior Common Room or Combination Room feels very much like that which I have observed in London clubs. So the Colleges are indeed clubs. It is legally possible for University Teaching Officers in Cambridge not to join a College. If they do not join a College, either as a full Fellow or in some other association such as Director of Studies, their obligations are minimal and they can get on with their research and keep their administrative duties and undergraduate teaching to a reasonable level. But

³ Emerson, *Traits*, 79, 91

⁴ Laing, *Observations*, 290

in a city of clubs, most people feel excluded if they have no College attachment and many enjoy the conviviality and sense of belonging, even if it also brings extra work.

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Cambridge may have that powerful feeling of a club that once a member, of the University, Department, College or whatever, you have a certain automatic bond with other club members. Yet there is one big difference which makes it much more than a club.

The central feature of a club is that it has one overriding and usually quite specific goal. It is set up to join people together who want to play chess, football, cricket, row, sing, run, fly, debate or whatever it is. Even the big London clubs, while bringing together people from many walks of life, have a particular aim - conversation, meetings and entertainment for example.

It is true that the general goal of the college is also a defined one – ‘education’ – but education is a very broad category. Obviously Colleges have been principally set up to teach, but also to encourage research. The oath also specifies the upholding of ‘religion’. And furthermore, the methods of learning extend far beyond formal instruction. An undergraduate or graduate coming to Cambridge is not just learning the contents of a subject, but a way of thinking and, so it is believed, a way of life. The University is meant to instil a set of values, a morality, a mentality, a set of manners, etiquette, a philosophy, a set of bodily practices, and an invisible attitude to life or *habitus*.

The College is not merely a body, it is an ancient and living body, a ‘We’ that has existed for centuries and will, hopefully go on for ever. Again as Ziman and Rose put it succinctly, ‘Religion itself has largely fled from the colleges – but the cult of the College remains. It is far more than buildings and quadrangles, far more than boats and tennis courts, than dinners and tutorials. The College exists in history; it exists in all its members, resident and non-resident. A don of high historical sensibility may remark that “*We*” once owned a certain estate – and cannot tell whether he is talking of the sixteenth century, the nineteenth century, or of his own life time.’⁵

In some ways, the Colleges can become the object of a secular cult. ‘The best of their values are independent of time and context... The experience is mystical; it attunes one to the poetry of existence... Poetry is magic; it is not surprising that a college still stands at the centre of a secular cult. *Its* existence is more than us. *It* has claims upon us beyond rational necessities. ... the old men ... are the Elders amongst the priests of the shrine, and we cannot help being moved by them, for it was they who initiated us into its mysteries.’⁶

⁵ Ziman, *Camford*, 245-6. Peter Burke comments, ‘I have caught myself telling visitors that “we asked Christopher Wren not to destroy the Long Gallery when he was building the Chapel”!’

⁶ Ziman, *Camford*, 247

Some negative reactions to Cambridge

All this talk of trust and warmth tends to paint a largely positive picture of Cambridge. Indeed my experience has been, on the whole, positive. I have been fortunate, and had enormous support from my family and friends. But my own diaries remind me that there have been periods of loneliness, of frustration, of exhaustion, of deep anxiety. Cambridge can be stressful and even isolating and there have been times when I have felt a great desire to take early retirement, or at least a rest. A book on the place would be incomplete if it did not mention that many people find the University and the Colleges repellent or at least very difficult to handle.

Undergraduates are often desperately unhappy for a variety of reasons and postgraduates are often lonely, for research can overwhelm a person with its narrowness, boredom and anxiety about not achieving enough or with financial worries. Foreign research students often suffer the most, since they also have to deal with homesickness, the strangeness of British culture, the weather, and the food. Married research students, with the added problems of the possible unhappiness of their spouses, the pressures of child minding, are in the worst of positions.

The dons themselves, as I know, are often unhappy, their work and social life increasingly unsatisfying. 'Even for the dedicated scholar, these years have their difficulties. He may know, well enough, that he must expand his thesis into a book – but by the fourth, fifth or sixth year it has gone a bit dry and stale on him, and he would prefer to do something else. He knows that it was too narrowly conceived, that he is narrow, that the academic groove is narrow' but he must stay in it now.⁷ The decline of productivity in later life is amusingly described by D'Arcy Wentworth Thompson who described the fellows of a mythical Cambridge College as mostly 'of the cobra kind. They had swallowed their intellectual goat in early life, and were passing through the years of inactivity requisite for digestion.'⁸ The pain of indigestion is added to nowadays by the anxiety caused by the pressure to produce a stream of important works at short intervals in order to satisfy the various research assessment exercises upon which funding depends.

A picture which leaves the reader with the idea of placid College and departmental life would be very distorting. The stronger the bounds of community, the bitterer can become the feuds and factionalism. I have witnessed a number of savage altercations and found myself filled with rage and disbelief. These disputes are about power, privilege, reputation and many other things, including gardens, pictures and the shape of a new piece of furniture. It is just like families in the intensity of both the affection and the periodic outbursts of anger or scheming alliances.

It is probable that the intensity of these feuds have become lessened as the students and fellowship have begun to come from a wider background. For ninety-five percent of its history, as Ziman and Rose point out, 'even at the undergraduate level, the colleges are

⁷ Ziman, *Camford*, 119

⁸ Quoted in Garrett, *Cambridge*, 89

intensely English, intensely provincial.⁹ This has been changing. Peter Burke comments that ‘At Emmanuel, the postgraduates were often foreign by 1980, but the Fellowship was like the undergraduates, entirely Anglophone - we had a couple of Australians and a New Zealander. Between 1980 and now we have elected, first as Research Fellows and then as Official Fellows, and not counting black British or British Sikhs, citizens of France, Germany, Italy, Serbia, Romania, Iran, Taiwan, while the undergraduates have remained 90% British.’ I have witnessed the same change in King’s, and with the oxygen of people from all over the world, the feuding, but also some of the warmth, has evaporated.

On the whole, the recipe seems to work. Yet, somewhat paradoxically, the more it works and a person enjoys and admires the place, the greater may be the final bitterness one feels about it. When a person leaves, they feel an especial betrayal, which can turn into an angry rejection of the ‘Ivory Tower’ which they had half-hoped to live in, but turns out to be like any fairy-land, a place one has to leave. They may feel that it would have been better never to have seen the alternative, which can make the rest of life a frustration. Better never to have visited Eden and to suffer the expulsion.

As Rose and Ziman write, ‘Many graduates leave Oxbridge labouring under a burdensome sense of loss, disillusion and defeat. They suppose that there is a deep cleavage between the values of Oxbridge and the values of the world outside. For these values – the cult of personal relations, the aesthetic enjoyment of life, freedom from authority, dislike of hierarchy, contempt for material considerations, the admiration of pure intellectual skill, the disinterested pursuit of truth, a spacious, speculative and untrammelled approach to life – they have often developed a passionate liking and respect. Their mere acceptance of these values makes it painful – almost humiliating – for them to recognise that they will have to earn a living at some plebeian but useful task. ... The prime basis for their diffidence is that they feel that they have been educated for a social structure that no longer exists.’¹⁰ More mildly, as one final year undergraduate put it to me, ‘It seems very rude when they ask us to leave’.

Yet, to end on a more positive note, many others, after a feeling of rejection, or at least deep sadness, a heightened sense of that one feels after a wonderful holiday or honeymoon, get things back into proportion or, as I read recently, think of Cambridge as ‘three years of premature retirement’. As in the famous musical ‘Salad Days’, there is no point in trying to relive or rejoin the experience, except for the odd evening of reunion. Yet to know that this other world existed and continues to exist can be a solace.

Families in Cambridge

Most societies in history have been based on family ties, the relations of blood and marriage. These organizing principles, though formally banished as major features in deciding jobs and social organization in ‘modern’ societies still persist in much of the world. They can be found in the secret organizations based on the family like the mafia,

⁹ Ziman and Rose, *Camford Observed*, 109

¹⁰ Ziman, *Camford*, 237

in nepotism, in family firms, in god-parenthood relations and ‘quasi-kinship’ in most societies.

I was surprised to discover that ever since the Anglo-Saxon period, extended kinship relations have been relatively unimportant in England. Unlike Africa, China or elsewhere, the English do not have, and have never had, clans or kin-based lineages. The only strong kinship unit over the last thousand years has been the nuclear family, which is the mother, father, sons and daughters. Even this small group broke up quite soon, for the children left home in their teens and set up a separate residence.

I have spent much of my life as a historical anthropologist refuting the myth that the small nuclear family has only recently emerged from larger kinship groupings in England, supposedly as a result of the industrial revolution. Our present small family system goes back as far as the records exist. It seems to have been introduced and remained fairly constant since the period after the fall of the Roman Empire in Britain.

Cambridge is a good example of this unusual anti-familistic tendency. It was recognized from the start that perpetual, wealthy, foundations would have a tendency to become a family business. Warmth and obligations towards offspring and nephews would have to be kept at bay if this was to be avoided. The obvious solution was not to allow people to have sons and daughters and, if possible, to limit the number and hold of nephews. So for over three quarters of its existence, Cambridge Fellows lost their fellowships if they married. A College was like a monastery. The elaborate arrangements of servants, kitchens and rooms provided an alternative to the support of kin, assuring lodging, food, drink and help until death.

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In practice, kinship has always played some part. The Isaac Newton family never came to colonize the place, but to a certain extent other families have done so. This does not seem to be a straight matter of favouritism, but rather of a loose network of inter-relations of cousins and second cousins. Noel Annan has investigated the actual kinship of these families¹¹ and it is apparent in a number of the interviews I have made of leading scientists (Keynes, Huxley, Bateson, Hill). Among these families were many of the great Cambridge names and many of outstanding merit. They also intermarried with others, the Bernal, Waddingtons, Braggs and others who formed their own kinship linkages across the universities.

While these families never became formal groups, and I know of no evidence that family favouritism rather than ability was the reason for their success, there is obviously an interesting counter motif or shadow of kinship here. The golden age of Cambridge in the later nineteenth and twentieth centuries is suffused by stories of large houses and parties and performances in which these ‘cousins’ would meet and form loose, useful, contacts. One member of the Darwin-Wedgwood dynasty, Gwen Raverat, in her *Period Piece*, lovingly portrays some of this world.

¹¹ See Annan, *The Dons*, pp. XX

Peter Levy provides one description of such inter-related cousinhoods. ‘The Darwin-Wedgwood-Cornford-Raverat clan frequently held very large gatherings of the extended family; and the presence of Maitlands, Huxleys, Fishers, Keyneses, Vaughan Williamses, Trevelyan, and Peases reminded them that they were part of a world that also included Tennysons, Macaulays, Hodgkins, Arnolds, Penroses, Wards, Frys, Booths, Potters, Stracheys, and Stephens. They knew that this world was privileged, but were proud that it was also civilized.’¹²

As Levy points out, this was partly caused and re-enforced in this period by the fact that Cambridge in particular recruited Quaker families - Gurneys, Barclays, Cadburys, Rowntrees, Frys, Gaskells, Sturges, Hodgkins, Foxes and Hoares, who were an intermarrying group. It was also encouraged by the arrival of a number of philosophical radical and Unitarian families ‘whose chief representatives were the Wedgwoods, Darwins, Trevelyan, Martineaus, Huxleys and Stracheys.’ We are told that ‘They preferred Cambridge to Oxford, possibly because the Tractarian Movement frightened evangelical families, and certainly because Cambridge, ever since the Civil War, had the more pleasant associations for nonconformist families.’¹³

This particular phenomenon, the rise of a certain part of the Victorian middle class, is one of the secrets of Cambridge throughout the last century. ‘An environment where creative behaviour is encouraged and expected is a great stimulus to creative behaviour, for it is conducive to intellectual boldness and a spirit of adventure. A tradition of such behaviour explains in part why the group produced such an enormous quantity of men and women of distinction...’¹⁴

The effects and nature of this loose group are well described by Levy. ‘Great things were *expected* of such a child. Being a member by right of birth conferred a sense of security crucial to the accomplishment of great intellectual deeds.... It is important to note that this intellectual elite is properly regarded as an aristocracy, for one was (and some still are) born into it... It was an open-ended group, in that meritocrats could marry into it...’¹⁵

This largely informal and rather invisible network, like the other societies and clubs and associations which are so important in academic life, is another factor which helps to give Cambridge a particularly entangled feeling. It is not a large clan, but some people are related. Reading the *Annual Reports* of Colleges, it is interesting how often there is an approving remark that so and so was the son or grandson or nephew of another earlier undergraduate at the College. Parents are often keen to send their children to ‘their old college’.

¹² Levy, *Moore*, 21, where there is also a kinship diagram of the connections. Another good description and analysis of the family connection is in an annex to Noel Annan, *The Dons*, pp.304-341

¹³ Levy, *Moore*, 27

¹⁴ Levy, *Moore*, 26

¹⁵ Levy, *Moore*, 26

Creating and subverting class in Cambridge

English snobbery has a particular flavour. It is based on a central contradiction. As many have noted, English class has never developed into a 'caste' system, that is into a fixed and rigid hierarchy based on impermeable, blood-based, strata. As Tocqueville remarked in the nineteenth century, 'England was the only country in which the system of caste had not been changed but effectively destroyed.'¹⁶ Wealth and a change of accent, as satirized in Bernard Shaw's *Pygmalion* can move a person up the social system. There has never been a proper blood nobility or a blood-based gentry. In this sense, England has always had an 'open' social system. 'English history is aristocracy with the doors open. Who has courage and faculty, let him come in. Of course, the terms of admission to this club are hard and high.'¹⁷

Combined with this, and indeed no doubt partly caused by it, is an obsession with class and status. 'England is the most class-ridden country under the sun. It is a land of snobbery and privilege...' as George Orwell observed.¹⁸ There is an infinite set of minutely graded differences, with an ever present chance of rising into a higher one, or slipping downwards. So class rivalries and snobberies have been a central obsession with the British. We only have to think of the work of Thackeray, Austen, Trollope, Mrs Gaskell, G.B.Shaw, Oscar Wilde and Nancy Mitford to bring this to mind. As Stendhal wrote about England, 'Society being divided as by the rings of a bamboo, everyone busies himself with trying to climb into the class above his own and the whole effort of that class is put into preventing him from climbing.'¹⁹

Cambridge can thus be seen as a powerful machine for establishing class. The University manufactures 'distinction'. Yet the social background of those who have come to Cambridge has varied. We tend to look back to the eighteenth and first half of the nineteenth century and think of it as traditionally taking members of the aristocracy, the gentry and the upper yeomanry. But for its first four hundred years it had a much wider social recruitment. For example Elizabeth Ledham-Green comments that from the thirteenth to fifteenth centuries 'The great majority of students were probably of yeoman stock or their urban equivalent.'²⁰ This is what one might call the middle middle class in modern terms.

It is particularly between the eighteenth and mid-nineteenth century that Cambridge trained people in 'manners', gave them the connections and self-confidence, and graced them with the social cachet of having been to Cambridge. For the rest of their lives they could regard themselves, and were usually regarded, as part of that prosperous, educated,

¹⁶ Tocqueville, *Ancien Regime*, 89

¹⁷ Emerson, *Traits*, 134.

¹⁸ Orwell, *Lion*, 52

¹⁹ Quoted in Wilson (ed.), *Strange Island*, 164

²⁰ Ledham-Green, *Cambridge*, 25; she notes that Roger Ascham in the sixteenth in *The scholemaster*, lamented the general disinterest of the nobility and the landed gentry in such a form of education.

liberal upper middle class (or above). They were the professional people, the rich businessmen, the gentry and the rulers.

Writing of the Victorian and Edwardian periods, Ziman and Rose note that 'The Public Schools and the reformed Universities constituted a single educational sequence for the sons of gentlemen and of others who could pay for it. From the Lower School at Rugby to Degree Day at Oxford, boys were being prepared to take their place as officers in the chain of command of a stratified society.' It had a great effect everywhere. 'It is the sun round which a great many other institutions of Lower and Higher Learning see themselves as revolving.'²¹

The bewigged figures who gaze down at us from the portraits in the dining halls or are remembered on plaques and stones were largely confirmed in their position by the process of passing through Cambridge. Others were the sons of rich merchants or farmers of a more lowly background who had used Cambridge as part of their strategy to move up into a higher rank.

Nowadays, of course, it is more complicated, and the situation is perhaps returning much more to the situation which has prevailed for most of the history of the University where it takes people from a more varied background. Though Cambridge is still a natural step for clever children from the upper middle class, it is also increasingly full of others. There are many foreign students of indeterminate standing, obviously wealthy but with hazy social credentials. There are also an increasing number of what used to be called the lower middle class or even the remnants of a sort of blue-collar class, ethnic minorities and others.

There is not, and never has been, a carefully thought-out strategy or program to indoctrinate people in class-consciousness or the tools of social elevation. It is just assumed that spending three years in an upper middle class environment will shape people. People's accents will be smoothed, they will gain the manners and etiquette and learn the linguistic tricks, they will gain the tastes in food, pictures, furniture and general culture, so that they can live a comfortable middle class life after University.

All this is an informal matter. I do not remember ever discussing what was happening when I was a student or in my years as a don at Cambridge.²² Yet it is so obviously there. Sometimes it causes bitterness or confusion in those who come from a different background. It is especially puzzling for foreign students, who may not know that they are entering a world where many gestures, postures and words carry a considerable significance to some of the local inhabitants.

²¹ Ziman, *Camford*, 231-2

²² Alison Richard comments that at Yale, where she was Provost, she had noted that somehow, without formal training, young people, who had come up with no ability to shake hands and held out limp and awkward hands in the 'hand-shaking' ceremony at the start of their course, three years later as they left they had mysteriously learnt the art of the positive and clean hand-shake.

Of course, social position is now pretty confused and contested. In my own Department, for example, the majority of the teachers are no longer middle-class English men. They mostly come from other parts of the world, half of them are women, and they do not snugly fit into the English class system. The situation is moving into a far less hierarchical structure.

Cambridge may no longer be filled with 'Hooray Henrys'. The strangely dressed 'Trinity Foot', scrambling without horses but in full hunting regalia across the countryside, may only survive as a pub sign on the busy A14 road. But vestiges remain and Cambridge undoubtedly still has a snobbish appeal and value to some as a sort of superior intellectual finishing school for young gentlemen and ladies. As I warm to the glow of being addressed as 'Sir' by the college porters, and being waited on at meals amidst the silver and wine glasses, I am aware of this largely vanished age.